Pointlessness and Boy Perfume

from Drums, Girls and Dangerous Pie

By Jordan Sonnenblick

INTRODUCTION

During hard times it's easy to wallow in self-pity and only think about getting what you want. But, sometimes, even in times of trouble it's about denying what you want for the good of another…for the good of your brother. "Pointlessness and Boy Perfume" by Jordan Sonnenblick

If you had a father who hadn't shown any emotion for three or four months, and then you stumbled upon him weeping as though someone had just shot Bambi right in front of his eyes, what would you do? Right-you would sneak away, and never let on that you had seen anything. And that's what I did. I crept back into the basement like a highly skilled sneak thief, and then proceeded to listen to the most calming music I know: the Beatles. Somewhere between "Revolution" and "Hey, Jude" I fell asleep. When I awoke in a small puddle of my own drool on the ratty playroom carpet with my left earphone seemingly welded to my head by the force of gravity, I looked at the Zildjian cymbal clock my parents once got me for a birthday. It was 11:45 p.m. I felt pretty sure of two things: nobody had noticed that I was hidden away in the dark basement like a leper, and everybody would be asleep when I went upstairs this time. For a change, I was doubly right. In the kitchen, I couldn't help but notice that my dad's mysterious pile of depressing papers was just sitting on the table, in plain view.

To see or not to see? That was the question. Well, for about a tenth of a second, anyway. Then I dove on those papers like Sherlock Holmes on a cappuccino binge. What I was looking at, what had turned my strong, silent dad into a weepy mass of

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pudding, was a stack of bills. Medical bills. Jeffrey's bills. The top sheet, which was written in my dad's handwriting, was a tally of the total unpaid amount to date: $27,000. The total expenses so far were unbelievable, definitely in the six-figure range. If not for the fact that my parents both had good health insurance (which I knew from overhearing some discussions about this stuff), we would already have blown the whole cost of a college education in these three months-and I knew Jeffrey was going to need at least three YEARS of treatment. As it was, I figured I'd be attending the "University of 'Would You Like Some Fries With That?'" There was no way either of us would have any kind of college fund at the end of this. Then I had an even more depressing thought: Jeffrey might not be around long enough to go to college.

OK, so we were losing money hand-over-fist, my dad was crumbling like a day-old scone, and my brother might die. Really, what could I do about any of it? At the moment, the only answer I could come up with was, "Nothing."

I went upstairs to get ready for bed, and a new obsessive slogan started running through my mind. It worked like this: "OK, I'll brush my teeth now. But Jeffrey might die, so what's the point? Time to wash my face. But Mom's not working, Dad makes maybe $40,000 a year after taxes, and there's $27,000 in unpaid bills downstairs. We're going to be homeless any minute-so what's the point? I should floss now too, but I didn't even brush, so what's the point?" So I went to bed with a grimy face and yuck-encrusted teeth. And that was just the start of my depressing "What's the Point?" period.

The next day, I came back from my week of absence to a barrage of "oh my god what's wrong with Jeffrey is your mom okay how's your dad taking it what you were sick oh." You can imagine that that didn't snap me out of my funk too well.

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Renee talked with me all through homeroom, which should have made me ecstatic, but I just kept thinking, "Soon I'll be leaving school to go live under an overpass, so what's the point of Renee liking me now?" Also, somewhere in the back of my mind I was realizing that she hadn't suddenly discovered that I was an actual human-being-type-person because of any new attributes I had developed; she was just fascinated by me as a tragic figure, for the moment. I still couldn't help going gaga over how beautiful she was, but I was almost mad at her, because she wasn't noticing me for the right reasons.

Annette was truly concerned about me, though. In Miss Palma's class, she offered to come over after school a few days that week and catch me up on my classwork in every subject we had together. That was pretty comforting, because I didn't want to fail all of my finals after the massive make-up effort I had done before my flu episode, and Annette always got A's in everything.

There was one problem: my math period was Annette's piano period, so who would bail me out in math? I was tempted to say, ''I'm going to fail the hardest subject anyhow, so what's the point?" I didn't, though-I was determined to pull all of my grades through this so I wouldn't add to my parents' worries. In math class, I went to the teacher and told him I would need help if I wanted to learn the week of new material I'd missed. I was torn between hoping he'd offer to meet me during our opportunity period and teach me the stuff himself, and being afraid that spending that much time one-on-one with a math teacher would crack me completely and turn me into a deranged lunatic. "Oh, well," I figured, "At least I'll be the life of the under-bridge party crowd then."

The teacher did not offer to catch me up, though. Instead, he asked for a volunteer who was willing to tutor me at home. And he got one: Renee Albert. Holy

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cow. Renee Albert was coming to my house! RENEE ALBERT WAS COMING TO MY HOUSE! Even *I* couldn't think, "What's the point of Renee Albert coming to my house?" with a straight face. I just said, "Wow, thanks, Renee!" while every other guy in the class looked at me like I had a big target painted on my forehead.

It was one of my drum lesson days with Mr. Watras, and when I walked in he handed me a crumpled tissue, pointed to the garbage can, and told me to show him my newfound hoops skills. I got it in - swish! - and sat down at the drum set. It was a great feeling to be playing drums after more than a week away from them, and Mr. Watras must have understood because he just sat back and watched me burning around the kit at full speed for a couple of minutes. When I stopped, he surprised me by talking about my academic situation, which we had never discussed again after the ugly meeting I'd had with my teachers.

So, I hear you've made up all of your old work.

Yeah.

Do you have a plan .for making up the work you missed last week and studying for the final?

Yes, Annette is going to tutor me in everything except math, and this, um, other girl is going to help me with the math.

Great! Listen, Steven, I'm really glad you're back on track with this school stuff. We absolutely depend on you in All-City, and I'm thrilled that we can keep you in the ensemble.

Me, too.

But part of me was thinking, "What's the point of practicing for a stupid concert when my brother might not live to see it?"

The week went by like that, with me going to school, my mom and Jeffrey

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coming and going between home and Philly, my dad staring off into space even more than he had been for months. I kept having those, "What's the point of . . ." moments, but plugged away at life pretty consistently anyway. And Annette came by three times to help me study.

You know what? She's an amazing tutor. I understood everything when she explained it, and got hundreds on a social studies quiz and a science lab thanks to her. There was an awkward moment when she first saw Jeffrey, because it was her first time seeing him all bald and puffy, but she covered her shock well. And by the second night, she was playing board games with him every time she took a break while I did practice quizzes or writing assignments. He was happy with the attention, and I noticed something interesting: she was much more patient and honestly excited to play with him than I was.

So Annette was the absolute perfect tutor-pal, and I should have been kissing the ground beneath her feet and carrying her book bag to school every day, right? But even while I was getting so much from her, I couldn't stop thinking about next week when Renee would be coming over.

On Thursday night of that week, Mom and Jeffrey left for a quick two-day trip to Philly for blood counts and a couple of chemotherapy injections. The procedures were pretty routine by then, but the results weren't. Jeffrey's counts were really low, so low that the doctors gave him two transfusions: one of whole blood, and one of platelets. This turned the two-day trip into a four-day trip. I heard my dad on the phone saying that the hospital bills were running about $2,000 a night, so I knew our financial picture wasn't getting any rosier. Also, my mom told me that Jeffrey would probably be even more vulnerable to germs for the foreseeable future, so I should be extra-careful to avoid being near anyone who was sneezing

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or coughing, and wash my hands when I walked into the house every day. I asked if I should just stay home and live in a plastic bubble with Jeffrey, and she warned me that I might, in fact, have to stay out of school for a while if something like chicken pox started going around.

So I was freaking out. On the one hand, my head was a mess of tumbling worries: rising poverty, falling blood counts, alarming potential for quarantine. On the other hand, Renee was coming! RENEE WAS COMING! To! My! HOUSE!

Tuesday was the big day. Midterm exams were a week away, so I needed Renee's help pretty big-time. Also, I couldn't get past the excitement part of the deal: Renee! In my house! I missed math for a drum section rehearsal (you really have to love the logic of getting called out of math for band right before exams), and Renee wasn't on the bus on the way home from school. So we didn't confirm that she would be coming over, but I assumed the plan was on for 7 p.m., which was what we had arranged the week before.

I ate with my mom and Jeffrey at six; my dad was still at his office. It was the beginning of tax season, when accountants get busier and busier leading up to April 15th. I figured we could use some extra income, so I was betting my dad would be really busy this year. Anyway, my mom noticed that I was being quieter than usual, and Jeffrey started in:

He's saving up all his smooth talking for his big date with Renee Albert!

It's not a date nut-ball, she's just tutoring me in math.

I bet you're gonna kiss her, right?

She has a boyfriend, Jeffrey. You know that. She's still going out with Biff, the guitar player.

But she's coming over to play with you.

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She's not playing with me, she's teaching me about numbers and stuff.

So when are you going to kiss her then?

MOM! The kid is out of control. Can't we get him dome tranquilized or something?

Then my mom got rolling:

Steven, is there something going on between you and Renee? I notice you're dressed more neatly than usual, and your hair is even combed down.

And he's wearing boy perfume, Mom. He wasn't wearing any last week when Annette came over, but for RENEE he is.

It's called cologne, monkey boy!

Since when do you wear cologne to learn math? Oh, my son is growing up right in front of my very eyes. Maybe I should get out the video camera.

Maybe you should tie me to a stake, douse me in kerosene and torch me right on our front lawn.

I won't need any kerosene, Steven –I'm sure the cologne will go up pretty fast.

Ha ha, Mom.

Just then the doorbell rang.

Please keep the lunatic away from us, Mom. We have work to do.

Is it hard work or easy work Steven?

MOM! REMOVE HIM!

I went to answer the door, and when I opened it, Renee was standing there, all bundled up against the winter, with a few snow-flurry flakes on her jacket. Her cheeks were flushed from the wind, and her hair was blowing around. I just wanted to reach out and brush the strands away from her face, but that didn't seem like a good tutorial beginning, plus Biff looked like the kind of guy who could rip my arms off and use them as toothpicks. So I just said hi instead.

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She said hello back, and I was just about to step aside and let her in. But just then, she sneezed. And coughed. And sneezed again.

Excuse me, Steven. I'm coming down with dome kind of virus thing, I think. I went home early from school today, and skipped cheering but I did't want to stand you up. You have too many big problems going on, I just couldn't let you down. So I'm here. Let's get to work!

I blocked the doorway with my body, and said something that seemed to float up from a place beyond my worst nightmares:

Renee, I can't let you in.

What do you mean? It's cold out here, and we've got a lot to do.

I mean, I'm sorry, but I can't let you come into this house. You're sick, and Jeffery can't get sick right now.

Steven, you're being ridiculous. It's probably just a cold, anyway.

A cold could put my brother in the hospital.

Steven, what's really going on? Do you hate math so much you just can't stand it? Do you want to fail the final? Then I wish you would have told me that before I came stomping through the snow to come over here.

Renee, I'm serious, this isn't about math.

And it can't be about ME. Any boy in the school would be drooling to have me come over. And everybody says you've had a crush on me since third grade, haven't you? Now just let me in!

I'm sorry, Renee. Do you want me to call your mom to come get you?

Without responding to me directly, she spun around on her heels like the dancer she was, and marched away. I could hear her muttering about me all the way to the end of the driveway:

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Ugghh! I walk to the boy's house in a BLIZZARD and he doesn't even let me in! He drools over me for half a DECADE but when I deliver myself to his front door he slams it in my face! I will NEVER understand boys!

At that point, she fired a parting shot over her shoulder: *Go ahead, then, fail math, and be lonely the rest of your life.*

As I slumped against the doorframe, staring at her back and wondering how she could be so graceful in snow boots and a parka when she wasn't even feeling well, Jeffrey came up behind me.

You know, Steven, you were right. I guess you aren't going to kiss her.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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